recipient. In such a situation, arguably, a neutral role would have helped India retain its goodwill among all Afghans, allay Pakistan's anxieties (or even contain its regional ambitions), and expand its economic footprint like the Chinese, the Americans, and multinational companies such as Bridas and Unocal.[9] None of this happened.

There is, in fact, no evidence to suggest a split-opinion in India on the question of engaging with the UF, like there was vis-à-vis engagement with the Taliban. The UF commanders, especially Massoud, were treated like secular 'heroes' in Indian circles. The partisans had come to dominate both policy and discourse on the Taliban dilemma. The question on the UF simply was about how to engage with them: whether to provide military support or not. The covertness of these operations and the Taliban's unpopular dominance on the international (and Indian) news wires makes granular analysis of this relationship difficult. However, a study of MEA documents, statements by Indian officials, declassified US intelligence reports, primary interviews with Indian and Afghan officials facilitating this relationship, and media archives are revealing. Despite being on the same page politically, the UF was more important for India's Afghanistan policy than the other way round. Also, India was the least important cog in the regional wheel that ensured the survival of the UF, until the US intervened militarily after the events of 9/11. In fact, according to some Russian officials, Pakistan's support for the Taliban paled in front of what Rabbani was receiving from Iran.[10]

Three aspects highlight the complexity of this relationship. Firstly, India's relations with different UF factions began with discord before they became functional and gained momentum. Most commanders such as Massoud, Dostum, Mohaqiq, Abdul Haq, and Haji Abdul Qadir (all former Mujahideen) had been critical of India in 1992. 'India had let down the Afghans and we hope that efforts are made to rectify these mistakes', said Abdul Haq, from the *Hizb-e-Islami (Khalis)* on 30 April 1992.[11] Indian journalist Shekhar Gupta, who was in Kabul at the time, interviewed Massoud two weeks later to check whether he shared Haq's anger on India. Massoud did not pull any punches: 'we want friendly relations with all countries. But we cannot forget India's policies during our Jehad'.[12] India's failed attempt to rescue Najibullah had not impressed the